

My Pottery Collection

Dedication

To my past self, I offer these prayers.

Acknowledgements

Thank you, David Bowie, for pouring your mortality into art. “Lazarus” lit a beacon that helped me march through dark days.

Thank you, Andrea Gibson, for baring your beautiful soul to the very end. “Come See Me in the Good Light” showed me there was another way.

Content Warnings

Content by piece title.

- Self harm and suicide: Milestones, Coding Patient, Tools
- Serious illness: Chromatic Roads, Coding Patient, Tools
- Substance abuse: Milestones, Falling
- Car crash: Falling

Contents

I	1
Pottery	2
Dimming Lights	4
Carving Rules	5
Milestones	7
Stitched Whole	9
II	11
Chromatic Roads	12
Coding Patient	14
Factually Speaking	15
Off Book	16
He's Hurting	18
III	19
Tools	20
In Rearview	22
Falling	24
Tattoos	26
Crash Report	27
IV	28
To the Gardener	29
Jazz	30
Dancing Between	31
Fire	32
My Child	33
Canyon River	34
V	36
Pieces of Me	37
Intermission	39

I

Pottery

Through my nascent eyes,
the world is blaringly new.
Every shape and intricacy
inspire utmost attention,
awe from each new insight,
and excitement to fold clay,
gifted to doting caretakers.

Through my collegiate eyes,
there are endless bowls.
A sea of collected gems,
with perspectives in hues.
I awe at what is known.
My putty, drops in oceans.

Through my workaday eyes,
monotony blankets experience.
Mud is paired with TV dinner.
This is water; I am fish.
Awe is a seldom surprise,
a jitter from a pretty radio.
Mundane fodder floats away.

Through my weary eyes,
the grief of my past lingers,
pelted shapes drown in static.
I am compelled to polish.
This is water; wet the slip.
Light the dormant kiln within.
Set amorphous wounds stable.

Through wizened eyes,
the curves of unexpected life
are my lumpy glazed anthology,
penned for my reverence.
May the shapes here published
help another begin sculpting,
or just collect pocket change.

Dimming Lights

A child delights in what's new.
 Seasons of joyful gifts
 from forgotten relatives,
 wrapping strewn about in glee.
 I count boxes, tallying expense,
 these, my short-lived delights.

Adolescence grows into a perceived self.
 What is this world and who do I wish to be?
 This tinsel, that greed, those lusts.
 What in this wild torrent of desire do I permit?
 What in this rotting plastic hell will survive?
 My self-disgusted ache linked to climate fears.

Adulthood sees community in custom,
 traditions twinkle in the darkness,
 with warm expressions of care.
 Oh, a basic tool of my forgotten hobby.
 Kind coworker, I must thank you,
 lest I seem ungrateful,
 despite the adolescent murmurs
 of shame and dread.

If it is love you express, then surely love will hear.
 Though kindness sparks joy in your selection,
 I wish for nothing but your affectionate presence.
 Share this tea, and tell me all about the light and dark in you.
 Truly. No, I do ...
 accept your gift card to store unholy, for items undesired.
 Yes, much easier than steeping in our sorrows.

I wish I could see the lights glisten,
 and hear the songs in proper spirit.
 I accept your practice and what you wish to share,
 feeling more unseen and alone for unseasonal thoughts.
 Each card a bright light of missed connection
 that pushes me further out into the cold.

Carving Rules

My father kept in his heart a book of Responsibility.
 Never did he share a copy, or print out a page,
 but, in his lectures and deeds, he transferred each Verse,
 like rules carved into a wooden placard hung above my subconscious.

Verse One: Honor Thy Commitments.

I was an uncoordinated rookie in a unfamiliar sport,
 frustratingly kicking a ball offside
 under laser scrutiny of bullying masculinity.
 But, somehow, at his discretion,
 this was 'my' commitment that I would see through the season.

Verse Two: Demand Thine Utmost.

I was a frazzled dish sponge stolen from a sink,
 placed before academic oil tanker spill, destined,
 through sacrifice of youthful purpose,
 through pains of inept shame and struggle,
 to achieve As, and show my worth to the world.

These lessons shaped the man I became.

For five years, I was a naive mechanic,
 adjusting the sleep and coffee settings,
 squeezing an ounce more power into academic race.
 A dedicated practice of revisions
 that left my heart discarded in a lockbox,
 undeserving of kindness until the next battle was won.

For nine years, I was a long haul trucker,
 partnered with a beautiful copilot,
 for quiet chore runs and cute date refuels.
 Endurance sacrifices, career cargo across state lines.
 I followed the itinerary, as best I understood,
 shipping laundry, with lockbox on the dash,
 as if a clean rig could replace the joy she once felt,
 or awaken her courage to repair.

My father is a different man.
The weight of duty lingers in his noble deeds.
His stern voice, now soft with distant echoing pride.
My wood remains carved.
Doctorate awarded, partnership done.
My uncaged tearful heart stirs as her own companion,
awakened by poignant teachers who proclaim her wisdom.
I cautiously attend to her foreign trembling tongue.
With dull knife, she carves new Verse:
Compassion for Thyself.

Milestones

I'm four.

The balloon I gleefully received
doesn't stand as tall as he once did,
and is worse the following day.
I tearfully beg for him to come back.
My parents struggle to explain
that 'he' will 'die'
and I never want a balloon again.

I'm eight.

My mother places gloves I've outgrown
on the grave of her late estranged father.
She asks if it's okay to leave them.
I instantly know I will regret either choice.
I can leave them and wish I kept them,
or I can take them and leave wishing
my mom got to say goodbye like she wanted.

I'm twelve.

My school crush tells me she wants to cut herself.
I tell her best friend and the guidance councilor.
There are rumored cruel whispers.
My parents say I did the right thing.
Everyone says its a cry for help.
They don't seem to be helping.

I'm sixteen.

A family friend dies by his own hand, in his 80s.
A gregarious man who told tall tales of butterflies
at secret twelve-step meetings.
He leaves a note in a book by Camus
about choosing not to be a burden.
People say it's a sickness to feel like a burden.
I attend a secret meeting, wishing to understand him,
and the burdensome feelings we share.

I'm eighteen.
 I rush to English class
 excited to discuss the book, Camus,
 because the struggle is all so true, isn't it?
 I quickly learn that my classmates cannot relate,
 and I shamefully change the subject.
 My teacher quips that I'm destined to struggle.

I'm twenty.
 I'm handed a bouquet of flowers on a stage.
 I instantly think about how
 they would look on my grave.
 I only ever feel present
 playing a character who isn't me.

I'm twenty-two.
 I busy myself every minute of every day
 with some form of work or entertainment.
 I spend twelve-hour days in an office,
 and binge watch tv another eight.
 I'm exhausted just being me.

I'm twenty-seven.
 Every time the bus turns the corner down the street,
 I think about how I could make it look like an accident,
 and then I go buy more booze.

I'm twenty-eight and medicated.
 I plan my whole day around building healthy habits
 and avoiding buses.

I'm thirty-three and medicated.
 I'm learning to meditate,
 be okay with silences,
 and the practice of self-love.
 I enjoy watching the stars for the first time,
 and shed a tear of compassion
 for all the past versions of me.

Stitched Whole

I knew a dog once,
with wide shining eyes
and unlimited bouncing joy
borne of playful innocence.
My incontinent frustrations
alchemized quickly to shame,
and deep mutual care again.

I knew a lady once,
with charming goofy spirit
and stern purposeful drive
borne of ardent intent.
My responsible devotion
was betrayed when her words
rang hollow in fractured time.

I knew myself once,
with adventurous instinct
and passionate curiosity
borne from youthful drive.
My impulsive ticket stubs
were packed into memories
for career since dissolved.

I knew a churchly god once,
with limitless compassion
and contemplative solace
borne from vast eternity.
My pained doubt was chided,
learning from dusty pages
in an dirty cruel world.

Now, I sit alone
with rhythmic needle.
Imagining bright puppy dog eyes
gazing at me from the eternal.
Imagining responsible devotion
to spontaneous wandering joy.
Imagining the void left by curiosity,
now softened into an embrace for my inner child.

Show me how to stitch these siloed pieces whole.
One overwhelming blanketed experience –
how do I love?

II

Chromatic Roads

In our pastel blooming love,
you held the blue burdens of your past,
and I happily shared the load.
Baby-faced travelers aimed at a distant summit
of verdant self-discovery and silvery achievement.

Your heart grew stronger,
you learned to put the weights down.
You ran free, unaware
of the translucent tethers
that sprang back old burdens.
I was there to hold you still,
to kiss the new pink smile lines
brought on by the freedom of sprinting
in flushed crowds that, to my ears,
were disquieting ashen static
of silent tethers.

Let us embrace these stones
until they shrivel golden.
I dutifully sat with my own,
and felt rosy lightened.
I moved with umber pace,
painting with darker hues,
never discarding
any part of my palette.

I watched you vacillate.
Joy in yellows and choral,
then pinned to the couch
by sickly black venom.
I prayed you'd find
any hand to hold
to look into that dark well,
mine or any shade other,
as radiant delving beacon.

I failed as your teammate
in my unresolved discomfort
amid clamor of joyful flocks.
We saw diverging paths ahead.
The maps I drew of shared future
were dim, but steady.
I felt the painful absence
of your ink on our page.

We couldn't know the quiet toxins building in your chest.
A pale bony hand forced you to look into petrifying abyss,
and see all at once your mortality, grief, fears, and anguish.
Tempests of the deepest black blew hard in defiant opposition,
as we shut the door to your well, and you swallowed forgotten key.
In a grey world, I chauffeured you to poison the bile monster,
a hollow ocher sponge to your subsiding pain.

I am grateful for your vibrant crowds,
for how they infect you with laughter.
They eased my violet departing sorrow.
In cloudy rearview, I imagine your joy.
I sketch new roads colored by
the weight of what we've lost
and the compassion of letting go.

Coding Patient

You wanted to get married, you said,
and you needed me to want that too.
You pressed ice to a growing fever,
and denied all bitter medicines.
You pointed to a healthy future,
but left me to build a care plan.

You'd just been agreeing, you said,
because trauma said dissent was punished,
a scarred-over knife tip, never excised.
I believed we were meant for each other,
and tried every other procedure I knew.
Your fear of surgery made you numb,
choosing avoidance over trust and care in me.

You just needed to survive, you said,
under crushing weight of mortality,
you were the only patient you could see.
You amputated our relationship
for the sake of your own health.
Just a lapel pin on the white coat
you were destined to show the world.

You needed me there, you said,
demanding warrior's attention in hostile home
to fight suicidal infection,
resenting my please for shift change,
under barrage of steroidal anger.
You never took responsibility.

I was numb, but I kept my oath.
Under crushing weight
of hollow 'I love you',
I collapsed in the supply closet,
slumped against ice pack shelf,
and forgot all care for me.

Factually Speaking

“Don’t call it divorce. We were never married.”
she would say flatly, literally, truthfully.

Marriage isn’t just
sentimental handwritten Christmas cards,
seeing youthful smiles fade to weary lines,
sacrificed separate joys for paired resolve,
planning candlelit moments of reconnection,
and bittersweet joys knowing it’s imperfect.

We skipped out on all the other pieces.
A sweeping gesture on bent knee to wow’ing crowd,
and accommodating bickering family strife
for an extravagantly budgeted exhaustion party,
ending in big ‘adulthood’ courthouse signatures,
and cramped wrists penning thank-you cards.

Somehow, we avoided
tense projecting fights signaling an end,
tearful apologies clinging to reconciliation,
angry notes to lawyers seeking settlement,
and stiff backs before hawing therapists.

It just slowed, from celebrating to settling.
My house-husband choring, and prestige films
mismatched her raucous finish lines, and quirky cat videos.
My cerebral dive into the hard vulnerable chats,
and dedication to maximizing joy in grocery runs,
mismatched her avoidant diversions into stressor-du-jour,
and longing for a love that required showy celebration.

My loneliness yearns for retrospective with erstwhile best friend,
pinning for the comfort of familiar disappointing compromise.
It may ache like court dates and thumping stamps of finality,
but it certainly wasn’t, not literally.

Off Book

“Are you okay?”, she asked.
 This, my dear partner of 10 years,
 knowing I’m holding something inside,
 knowing that the chatter is too loud,
 or the conversation too grating.
 The answer is assumed, but my choice remains.

A seed of rejection was planted in my heart
 those months ago, when I tried to repair.
 “My life is bifurcated”, she said,
 in cutting resignation of what came to be.
 A challenge to integrate or fall away.

“Are you okay? Will you stay here?”
 Will you play your role in this scene?
 No, yes, wait – the lines in a foreign tongue.
 In my strength of dedication, I can speak,
 but my calcified form needs time to adapt,
 find the tone that makes this character me.

“Are you okay?”, he asked.
 This, my long lost friend of 20 years,
 curiosity led, bypassing any role,
 knowing that the world is loud,
 and the circus may be so grating.
 The answer is invited, all exchange remains.

The seed of rejection has since blossomed
 into constricting, choking vines.
 I tried to learn the tongue, and fit the mold.
 My mountain of struggle seen as bare minimum,
 contorting to find authentic voice under ivy,
 beaten by constant auditioning for a life
 I thought was ours to script together.

“Are you okay?”, a lingering question
from a dear friend, parting thick canopy.
Yes, I realized, to my own surprise,
because the blaring sounds of the world
can’t compete with the quiet comfort
of being invited to play the role of me.

He's Hurting

Contemptuous commands
shame dutiful compliance
from disdain,
lacking principled motivation,
especially barked
into a mirror.

I'm sorry.
You deserve better
than this forced narrow path.
I will learn to love you too.

III

Tools

My love was a builder.

I constructed our house to give you room to grow.

I didn't understand the shape, or fit in place next to you,

but I wanted so much to see you thrive

that I fashioned myself into one of the pillars.

A stoic fixture of self-neglect, longing for a kiss.

Instead of thrive, I watched you wither,

trapped by conviction that life made promises, undelivered.

The further you ran, the more our visions of fulfilling lives diverged.

To find your voice, it was time to cocoon.

I saw my pain of rejection as a speed bump

on your path to becoming a better you.

That this home did not fit your needs,

that I had become more pillar than occupant,

that I might fall away in the metamorphosis –

these were tearful bruises of my care.

But your cocoon was poisoned by cancer.

Reflection and meaning supplanted by anger and grief.

From catatonic sorrow, you emerged with distorted wings

like chained attack dogs protecting you from the blinding light of day.

They shouted, "Silence! Leave me to my suffering! Let me die!"

My hammer became a warrior's weapon.

I danced in panic, to dodge and block

the fears pulled from your heart,

lobbed as vengeful projectiles.

I was wounded and drained and needed rest.

I turned away, expecting to return renewed.

Instead, the dogs broke from their chains

and attacked us both,

promising a swift end.

My last act of bravery was to hide my heart.
Silent as commanded, I wept in secret.
The broken chains pinned you to the ground.
Neither the friend I remember,
nor the you I'd hoped you'd become,
only the ghost of rote action could emerge.
I held her hand long enough to pass it along to another shepherd.

Now I stare at my reflection in the altar of love
and I see the bright eyes of someone new behind me.
Am I a builder? Am I a warrior?
Could I learn to grow a garden?
Do I have the strength to use these tools
for myself before offering them to another?
In the doubtful quiet of night,
I look to my scars for the courage to adapt.

In Rearview

The billowing plumes of a breakdown,
tell a long story of habitually missed maintenance.

Driving shiny love off the lot,
newly meshed gears will travel for miles.
Long floral meanderings through quiet trails,
over a bickering hill, through a valley of doubt.
Approaching bumpy roads are immediately visible.
Within the first mile of rough terrain,
like unpaved paths of buried maternal traumas,
you either know you weren't built for this,
or you're more sure of the trip than before.
And we traversed those valleys beautifully.

But misunderstandings crunched between gears
can start cascading reactions that rattle.
This conversation that seemed more chore than worthwhile,
those misunderstood silent looks between moments,
are the drops of aging oil that need changing.
Propelled by momentum, I ignored the oil light.
I hit 'cruise control' to fiddle with the radio,
preoccupied by where we went, not how it felt.
There was discomfort in shared bed,
the timing belt skipped a tooth,
and fuel burned cooler.
Quiet jostles accumulated.

With a violent overheating crack,
with a painful, tearful, "it's over,"
I saw the road behind in sharp clarity.
The long history of unmet needs,
missed tune-ups and alignments.
That book she didn't read when I asked,
that party I skipped, hating those friends,
the trip we never planned
because life got in the way.
Failing to talk out our fears,
so "I'm hurting" became "It's fine"
and "Venting or fixing?"
left no room for either.

I can look back on the odd noises,
lacking signposts and landmarks,
only registered as subconscious unease.
I put too much faith in cruise control,
but, by the time I saw engine failure,
my cowardly copilot had already ejected,
deciding the unannounced warnings she saw
were beyond repair.

Those unheard rattles echo as pain and regret.
Looking out over stretching highway,
I want to develop the ears of a mechanic,
to listen to the bubbles of a concerned gut,
and tend to cracks before they tear.

Falling

In a crash, you plead for resolution.
Each step, begging it's the last.

The tires slip uncontrolled
"That's alright; a little ice."
A jolting turn, toward that ditch.
"Okay; that'll stop the car."
An uneasy pitch to the left.
"It'll be okay; just rocking."
Grit of broken window on teeth.
"Please stop"
Gnashing skid of metal on road.
"Where's the ravine?"
"Get out. Get out."

Bargaining prayers to a disbelieved god
under slow motion of adrenaline.
Get out. Stand on the firm ground and breathe.

I stood on the steering wheel,
and manteled over the passenger side.
I rushed to the responsibility
that had encouraged the reckless speed,
accomplishments line-itemed for competition.
"I focus better on no sleep."
"I can't give up now, I've come so far."
I carried the stupor of exhaustion,
throwing myself over the hill of any challenge.

If you pretend you never fell,
you never learn to get back up.

Until the furthest flung career ambition
required passport to leave behind
friends, and love, and support,
teams, and tradition, and Californian sun,
for cold Germanic indifference.
No throw could escape compounded dark gravity.
Grounded by vodka-stenched fog,
time collapsed inward, no past, no future.

Until a gentle stranger's eye contact,
asked how I was doing, without scripted reply.
Like a midday ray of sun into a dark well,
she reminded me that beauty could exist – somewhere else.
A slow motion wake up call I constructed
from hazy memories of how vivid purple used to be.
Get out. Get out.

If you remember every time you ever fell,
you remember every scape, bruise, and labored breath,
and that is always possible to stand back up.

Tattoos

When I met her, I made a quiet vow.
I needed no ceremony to mark the start.
I was certain in unblemished dedication.
Ready to become the best me in her embrace.
I spilled ink to mark the changing seasons,
our many tides, joy and grief shared,
swirled upon me like an altar to passing time.

When she left, I stared ahead,
at unpaved road pouring from my empty chest.
I am covered in indelible evocative marks.
Reminders of who I was and wished to be,
pining to offer myself as a blank slate,
to hurry and write a new comforting tale.
Why should devotion require emptiness?

When I was alone, I saw with fresh eyes
these cross-hatched decorative reminders
are the pieces of my earnest gathered wisdom.
Intricate lines reflecting my tender soul.
Revealing shapes of my path in all chapters.
My heart is heavy, unresolved, and uncertain.
I am an evolving draft, art in progress.

Crash Report

“Honestly, I didn’t know those gauges were there, officer.”
I always thought the blinking red underneath my degrees
was just a warning he would lurch on the next hill.
A stern finger points at revealed labels:
Pain, anger, grief – who knew they were separate?
A side of the dash I had never known, now overwhelming,
flashing in dire reds and blues over my numb eyes.
Grief looks spun around past zero, sluggishly fluttering.
The dealership should have mentioned something,
or at least given me an owner’s manual.
The ads for the Masculine models never cover these features.

“Thanks for towing me out of the ditch, officer.”
The wheel just started pulling to the side.
In the blizzard, I didn’t know what else to do.
I think I can sputter along to the next mechanic.
Won’t be cheap, but I think he’s got some miles left.
Maybe someone at the shop can teach me about the gauges.
I can’t afford repairs like this again.

“Oh, a cause, officer?”
He passes me a clipboard through the window,
a clinical form back-dropped by bitter wind.
A stern finger points to a short blank line.
Too many miles in to blame the manufacturer.
Poor public education? True of anything.
I did get off the highway pretty abruptly,
but it would be too easy to blame my ex.
All contributing factors in a nuanced story,
that history will remember with one conclusion.
I close my eyes and start to feel the dials hum,
like faint unseen tethers tangled upon my pulse,
pulling in all different directions.
I shrug and write, ‘User Error’.

IV

To the Gardener

You beautiful dancing laughter,
you cherished core with tender heart,
soaked in nourishing lifeblood
of vibrant experience and wounds.
Your soil is deliciously fertile
and you your own wise gardener.

I peer over perfunctory fence,
wincing at ignored broken knee.
I studiously note your technique,
to tuck between my myriad scars.
I scribble you warm letters.

My battle-hardened countenance
does not yet trust gentle reverence.
My painted armor stirs desire,
and in turn awakens my own passion.
There is joy and bounty in presence,
bathing in the glow of morning light.

Pray, caution against infatuation.
The clashes yet echo in cloistered corners.
Only reflection can banish lurking shadows.
I am indebted to your nurturing and vigor,
but I cannot place my recovery at your feet.
I must learn to be my own embracing nurse,
not yet knowing how.

I pilgrim to nocturnal desert rose.
I quiet the distracting lyre of praise,
assemble tools of unfamiliar labors,
and begin writing letters to my aching self.
I breathe the scents of awakened heart
and the first seedlings in my own garden.

Jazz

The struggling bulbs of dim lights flicker.
Sweet martini scents lacquer wooden history.
Musicians breathe in synchronized harmony,
riding delicate solo to towering crescendo,
that settles us like warm weighted blanket.

The cold sleet melts against vibrant panes.
The judging logic of careful observing ego,
evaporates in the whirling piano campfire.
Entranced presences nestled in burrow booth.
Delectable exchanged touch in fluid melody.
Your whimsical rhythm upon my beaded wrist,
my deliberate delicate traces of your dress,
softly pulse intrigue in candlelit sound.

Awakened spirits meld in tacit excitement.
Tangled physical tethers radiate warmth.
Effortlessly synchronized wandering fingers,
softly grip flutters on trembling high wire.
Amorous suspension over practical future,
a coy dance, as time shifts out of focus.

The frost, the notes, the tender affection,
deep breaths grasp at beautiful transience.

Dancing Between

Her hand outstretches in cautious trust.
 I pause to examine it from every angle,
 and announce each step of intellectualized intent.
 She laughs in charm, "Wow, it's nice to have a plan!"

I stumble over clumsy mislabeled feet,
 wincing to remember the right moves.
 Her smile clears away the dust
 from my ill-favored intuition.

"Just be all of you"
 throws fuel on my long-forgotten spark.
 Caution wraps my desire to march in time,
 coating actions in layers of audit,
 that shed like stages of a climbing rocket.
 I falter in my balance, so she leads.
 I regain confident composure. She exalts.
 Rhythm directs yearning in step and sway.
 Playful moves mold in reciprocal embrace,
 until beautiful joyous crescendo
 leaves us painting.

"You mean you don't have to plan?"
 Her eyes cherish the caution,
 and find respect in analysis,
 but let them fall away in visceral moments
 when faith in the holistic other can lead.
 "Only big picture. Trust fills the spaces between."

Fire

Of course love is a flame.
Any teen can set homework alight
and see jittering presence bloom.

With time, adults learn to nurture
nascent spark with tailored kindling.
We gather wood with kind patience,
to watch the same glorious steps
with a warmth deep as bones.
The smoldering committed embers
reignite under directed puff,
with crackle and spontaneous spark.

Some campfires triumphantly tango,
but sputter in woes of unexpected rain.
Some wildfires negligently breakdance,
consuming all to the horror of onlookers.
Some cast iron hearths gently sway,
warming quiet homes though patient tending
to keep bitter wind at bay.

Tend your fire well, listen and care.
May she have many seasons and homes.
Collect hearty long-burning logs
in extra supply for gloomy days.
An ephemeral story told but once,
with nuances only attention will see.
Delight in warmth and vitality
of dancing flame.

My Child

Breathe, little one.
Let it wash over you.
It does nothing to keep this storm inside,
but strain the muscles that cage it so,
force the trapped gales to fester,
and ensure they return redoubled.

Breathe, little one.
Be here with your anger and grief.
These ugly tempestuous faces may frighten,
but they are not here to stay.
They holler lessons and warnings from your soul.

Breathe, little one.
I am here to hold your hand, come what may.
I will love you in your joys.
I will love you in your sorrows.
I will love you in erratic indescribable winds.
Let them out, as tears, as shouts, as laughter.

Breathe, little one.
See the tempest within you as I see you.
With compassion and worthy of embrace.
See the wounds from which they hail,
be they the pains of worldly injustice,
or the tender scars you carry.

Breathe, little one.
Watching you heal brings me so much joy.
To see you shake loose atrophied limbs,
and watch your precious curiosity renewed.
You embody the bright light of the divine.
Breathe, and be free, my inner child.

Canyon River

I was born as rainwater
 upon my personal sands of time.
 Each season, I washed the landscape,
 collecting to slumber in distant sea,
 and forming thick clouds to rain anew.

Caretakers shape the water's path.
 "Go to school, wear your coat,
 this is how to be a good boy."
 Each rainfall erodes minute dust.
 "Don't shout at him, don't be sad."
 Energy rebuked diverts underground.

A young mind is loose surface soil.
 Any shouts of alarm or jarring pains
 flood biased gentle grooves into plains.
 This failure, that bully, those misses,
 sloped timid ambition to adjacent shame.
 This wish, that grit, those nerves,
 twinned many wins with self-neglect.

Time hardens stratified bedrock.
 Jaded and aloof, all not quite real.
 I endure familiar floodplains.
 Pay rent, find a job, make a meal,
 I do what I must amid changing tides.
 With resignation, I ache alone,
 a victim to a long eroded past.

No. I must become my own caretaker,
 a nomad in these internal lands,
 I see the flow in all its shapes,
 study the energies and seasonal paths.
 I plant shrubbery, nurturing crop,
 to protect the banks of safe waters.
 This body shame to patient acceptance.
 Those angry words to quiet love.

Gazing upon the deep carves of time,
I so wish I could backfill the paths
of pain, of sorrow, of self-blame.
I wish for new days of ingrained habits
of gratitude, of care, of serenity.
Drug-induced earthquakes crack the floor,
but no shortcut could divert all waters.
Only countless tiny mindful redirects.
Amid confusing lessons, and quiet relapse,
I tiredly will drops of liquid experience
to newly green bank of softened stone.

V

Pieces of Me

I left a piece of my heart in Connecticut,
sleeping with the acorns along a winding road.
Comfortably connected to familial stolen past.
Soccer practice mundanity is carried upon temperate wind.
Businesses pass from father to son, unchanged.
A misfit longing for metropolitan trains,
festering in stagnant water.

I left a piece of my heart in Paris,
among the drunken cobblestones, buried under pastry crumbs.
Shamelessly pretentious about the best of life's simple pleasures.
Clacking boots walk upon echoing history.
Social strife is dutiful tradition.
A detached outsider failing to grasp linguistic nuance,
eyes rolling at misused co-opted English.

I left a piece of my heart in SoCal,
toasting in the gentle sun, next to no-name taco stand.
Relaxing into the breeze of definitive pleasures.
The crashing surf collides with laughs around bonfire,
dulling harsh ambitions against present joy.
There is an illusory ladder between
sunken studio and canyon mansion.
Daily health-conscious expenses engender
painful unaffordable insecurity.

I left a piece of my heart in Santa Fe,
baking in the heat, tucked against shrub in vast expanse.
Sun-scorched defiance, beautifully rugged smile lines.
Gentle brushstrokes leak from inspired grey hands,
a lonely island of long shadows and divine sunsets.
An aesthetic, robbed from a native underclass,
decorates naive isolation in self-indulgent turquoise.

Inspiration in the dead of night is no challenge.
Artistic expression can be engaged, disciplined practice.

The rest of my heart happens to live in Chicago,
wedged between bricks of an aging lakefront high-rise.
Justice is stern and inviting, an unsleeping black fist.
The chatter of diverse, joyous community sings harmony.
Unruly bike tires meet ice, and heat, and ice again,
commuting between gym, duty, intimacy, and adventure.
A tiring multifaceted hodgepodge
that makes all else seem lonely by comparison,
however incomplete it may be.
“Doors open on the left at Lake”

Intermission

Away from cacophonous towers,
with icy paved rivers,
friendly compatriot laughter,
flirtatious smiles,
mundane insurance statements,
and blaring digital connection,
I stop, to reflect on the past.

From pastel painted skyline,
bold lengthened shadows
cast a golden dusty light.
The dry lung-burning cold
is interrupted by pine fumes
from cozy twinkling homes.

Alone with churning spirit and breath,
I remember all I had wished to be.
I map the course of unfamiliar places
and settle in deafening silence.
I grind, with pieces of dormant self,
the embers of chaotic past to coal bereft,
forming the inky wellspring for chapters new.